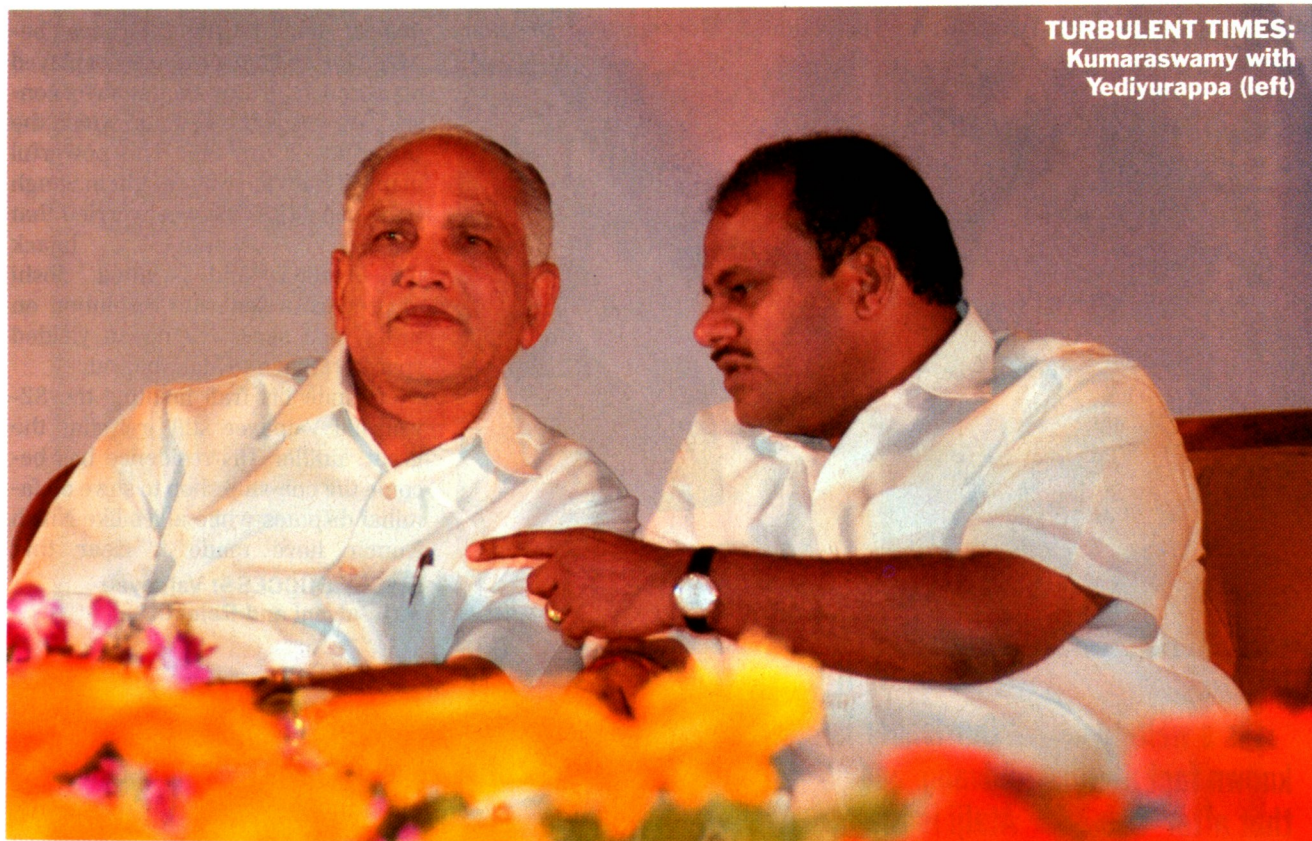


DOUBLE TROUBLE

With Deve Gowda hesitant in letting his son honour the power-sharing agreement with BJP and relinquishing the chief minister's chair, the Government may well be heading for a political crisis



TURBULENT TIMES:
Kumaraswamy with
Yediyurappa (left)

GIREESH GV

■ **By Stephen David**

Much as in 1994, JD(s) chief H.D. Deve Gowda today, has a battle on hand. Thirteen years ago, he was troubled by bete noire Ramakrishna Hegde's supporters over the issue of chief ministership. He had then managed to hold on to his own. This time it is BJP. The state's Chanakya, Gowda is now trying to save his son, Chief Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy's chair. He does not want the state's youngest chief minister to relinquish his chair to BJP on October 3, under the original power-sharing agreement. Kumaraswamy, 47, though keen to carve out a good name in politics, is caught in a cleft stick because of his father's stand.

It was Kumaraswamy who had

engineered a large-scale coup of sorts within JD(s) in February 2006 to form a coalition government with BJP—with 45 legislators as against BJP's 79—under a gentleman's agreement to share power for 20 months each before the scheduled 2009 assembly polls. "I want to honour my part of the agreement," says Kumaraswamy, but he knows there is little he can do to sway JD(s) legislators on his side. Weeks before Deputy Chief Minister B.S. Yediyurappa of BJP is to take over as the chief minister from Kumaraswamy, there is trouble brewing. The two parties, who shared a close bond in the past 20 months, are going it alone for the September 28 urban local body polls in over 200 constituencies in the state.

Chief minister-hopeful Yediyurappa says he hopes Kumaraswamy

will keep his word. But the question is whether Gowda will: on September 2 he appointed Bidar district legislator Merajuddin Patel the state JD(s) chief—the highest position a Muslim has attained in the party till now. Suddenly the so-called son of the soil is trying to play the minority card.

Currently, Gowda is waiting for his astrologers to advise him about the next course of action, which can most probably be asking his son to resign ahead of the scheduled transfer of power. The urban local body polls later this week are also expected to be a referendum on Kumaraswamy's style of governance, which involved staying in randomly picked houses of villagers across the state under his Grama Vastavya programme and patiently hearing out the thousands who